

The role of team leadership in Portuguese child protection teams

Leadership

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Abstract

The majority of team leadership studies have ignored the specific context in which that leadership takes place and the cyclical correlation of inputs and processes on ongoing performance. It is our contention that leadership is a mediator of team processes and team effectiveness on ongoing functioning of multidisciplinary teams (MDT). The members of 126 multidisciplinary teams responded to a survey on several aspects related to the functioning and leadership of their teams. The results support the hypothesis that leadership does mediate the relationship between reflexivity and effectiveness (i.e. team management performance, boundary spanning and satisfaction) within the team. Theoretically, these findings challenge those of linear models that typically analyse the impact of leadership as something that happens in isolation. Future research should describe and consider not just the team type and tasks but also investigate the roles that context and time play in team leadership.

Keywords

teams, team leadership, context, reflexivity, team performance, team satisfaction

Introduction

In recent years, there has been a growing consensus that intervention with abused and neglected children requires multiple professional competencies and community resources (Lalayants and Epstein, 2005). The use of multidisciplinary teams (MDT) has been one

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response to the complexity and multicausal prevalence of child abuse and neglect. Nevertheless, despite the large amount of empirical studies that focus specifically on child abuse and neglect (e.g. predictors, emotions, family context, consequences for children and family), few studies have explored the functioning and effectiveness of the MDT.

Ells (2000) defines a multidisciplinary child abuse team as 'a group of professionals who work together in a coordinated and collaborative manner to ensure an effective response to the reports of child abuse and neglect' (p.5). According to the author, an MDT has multiple functions, and in many cases is responsible for: investigating cases and identifying the main causes of children's maltreatment and neglect; defining social policy measures; the monitoring and referral of victims, their families and the perpetrators of abuse; or a combination of these functions. Bell (2001) adds that MDTs provide a holistic view of each case, in order to meet the legal, social, therapeutic and medical needs of the maltreated child. Along these lines, MDT outcomes largely depend on the way team members interact with each other (e.g. how they work, communicate and reach decisions together) to accomplish their task.

Although in this paper we have referred to Portuguese MDTs, the use of MDTs has been extended to many countries. MDTs can take several structures (e.g. safeguarding children boards in the UK and multidisciplinary teams in the US) and may involve different locales. However, the characteristics of these specific teams are shared. For example, the responsibilities of safeguarding children boards include auditing and evaluating how well local services work together, putting in place objectives and performance indicators for child protection, overseeing interagency training (Murphy, 2004), among others, complementing the work of MDT teams described earlier. The need for collaborative interagency work to protect children is shared by most of the countries using this type of team.

Although the relevance of the MDT for child abuse and neglect interventions is acknowledged, the empirical studies that address MDT functioning mainly focused on the burnout of its practitioners (Jenaro et al., 2007; Munn-Giddings et al., 2005), and the culture, organization and management of these units (Minvielle et al., 2005), among others. In such studies, the team is regarded as the action context of practitioner members, but not as a unit of analysis itself. However, there have been attempts to evaluate the effectiveness of this kind of team: describing their advantages and disadvantages (Lalayants and Epstein, 2005); comparing the structure and functioning of different MDTs operating in different countries (Bell and Feldman, 1999); studying the outcomes of the collaboration between agencies (Faller and Henry, 2000); and elaborating prescriptive guidelines for this multidisciplinary work (Ells, 2000; Murphy, 2004). Despite the relevance of these studies, there is still a lack of empirical studies on the interaction processes underlying these teams' members (an exception is the study of Bell, 2001, which studied the patterns of interaction or the way team members in child protection worked together within the team). In fact, there is a need for more consistent operational definitions of short- and long-term MDT outcomes and more qualitative and quantitative studies of the collaborative processes of MDTs, among others (Lalayants and Epstein, 2005).

Team literature points to leadership as being a key variable to promoting team effectiveness. Yet, the number of studies and conceptual models which focus specifically on team leadership or on the importance of group dynamics are few (e.g. Hackman and Walton, 1986; Kozlowski et al., 1996; Küpers and Weibler, 2008; Zaccaro et al., 2001)

and even fewer are the studies on leadership in MDTs that work on cases of child abuse and neglect. The study of Ahearn, Ferris, Hochwarter, Douglas and Ammeter (2004) can be seen as an exception. The authors of this study examined the role of leaders' political skills in the performance of casework teams in a large state child welfare system. Ahearn et al. (2004) defined political skill as 'the ability to effectively understand others at work, and to use such knowledge to influence others to act in ways that enhance one's personal and/or organizational objectives' (p.311), based on the work of Mintzberg (1985) and the measure from Ferris et al. (1999). The authors argued that leader political skill is one of those key skills that is critical to leadership effectiveness. Specifically, they suggested that leader political skill provides the social astuteness and behavioural flexibility and adaptability necessary to effectively address the needs and aspirations of followers, as well as to neutralize the barriers that might hinder team effectiveness. By increasing the interpersonal trust between leaders and subordinates, employees are more likely to commit themselves to the goals of the organization, and to take the steps necessary to maintain an acceptable level of performance, especially in public domains, such as child protection teams.

This study aims to contribute to the development of the theoretical and empirical knowledge of MDT functioning. It investigates the role of team leadership in team processes and performance in the specific context of the Portuguese Commissions for the Protection of Children and Youngsters at Risk (CPCY) teams.

The role of team leadership in teamwork effectiveness

Leadership is a broad area of research. Several theoretical models on the topic already exist and some empirical studies have been carried out. According to Kozlowski and Bell (2003), the theoretical models and empirical research of leadership have been conducted at different levels of analysis: individual, interpersonal and team. Most of the theories are positioned at individual level, identifying a set of general characteristics and behaviours of leaders (Bass, 1985; Jago, 1982); at interpersonal level, theories such as leader-member exchange (LMX) refer to a dyad linkage between a leader and a member (Dansereau et al., 1975), and the proposal that leaders do not treat all followers identically and develop a different quality of relationships with them (Boies and Howell, 2006; Graen and Uhl-Bien, 1995). At team level, theories are in smaller number and focus specifically on team leadership (Hackman and Walton, 1986; Kozlowski et al., 2009; Morgeson et al., 2010; Zaccaro et al., 2001), which is the focus of this study.

In general, leadership theories and research suggest that leadership is an important factor that has an impact on team processes and outcomes. Nonetheless, 'despite the ubiquity of leadership influences on organizational team performance, and despite large literatures on both leadership...and team/group dynamics..., we know surprisingly little about how leaders create and manage effective teams' (Zaccaro et al., 2001: 452). In fact, the number of empirical studies on team leadership is still small. Although the number of empirical studies on team leadership has increased in the last 10 years (Burke et al., 2006; Chen et al., 2007; Morgeson, 2005), the number of studies that specifically deal with how leaders assure the coordinated interdependence between team members is still small.

This specificity makes the difference between team leadership theories and other theories mentioned earlier at individual and interpersonal level. In fact, there are some

empirical studies about leadership in teams that use the approach of transformational leadership (Lim and Ployart, 2004; Schaubroeck et al., 2007) as well as the LMX theory (Boies and Howell, 2006; Cogliser and Schriesheim, 2000; Naidoo et al., 2008), which provide important results regarding how leadership behaviours influence subordinate attitudes, beliefs, motives, effort and performance. However, they focus on the individuals within a team rather than the team as a whole unit of analysis. Also, team leadership theories consider how team leaders foster team interaction processes, such as interconnectivity, integration and coherence among team members (Zaccaro et al., 2009). The role of leaders in the dynamic of these team processes allows the team to react to internal and external contingencies, as opposed to fitting the leader to the situations, as proposed by traditional leadership theories.

Most research on team leadership is based on the functional perspective, which considers that the leader's main task is to assure all functions that are critical to accomplishing the team's task and to group maintenance (Hackman and Walton, 1986; Kozlowski et al., 1996, 2009; McGrath, 1962; Zaccaro et al., 2001, 2009; Morgeson et al., 2010). The team leadership models based on this functional perspective arise from the input-process-output (I-P-O) team effectiveness models (Ilgen et al., 2005; McGrath, 1964). In this general model, the inputs are the set of individual characteristics that team members bring to the group, including team composition and resources available for achieving the task on multiple levels (individual, team, organization). The processes are related to the interaction of team members and they refer to activities in which team members pool their resources to perform tasks. In that sense, processes are mediators of the transformation of inputs to results. Finally, outputs are the products resulting from teamwork and may be used to evaluate their overall effectiveness. Based on this heuristic approach, team leadership models often point to leadership as an input variable, that is, the leaders and/or their leadership functions influence team effectiveness through several processes that can occur within the team (Zaccaro et al., 2001). In fact, research indicates that team leadership has an important impact not only on team performance (Burke et al., 2006), but also on members' affective reactions (e.g. Foels et al., 2000). A review of team outputs would be remiss if it did not mention team members' affective reactions and viability outcomes. Team, job and organizational satisfaction (e.g. Kirkman and Rosen, 1999; Tesluk and Mathieu, 1999) continue to receive the most attention from researchers.

Although the functional perspective has been a reference for team leadership models, some studies have been developed in the domains of coaching (Hackman and Wageman, 2005; Wageman, 2001), shared or distributive leadership (Al-Ani et al., 2011; Day et al., 2004; Pearce and Sims, 2002), empowering leadership (Kirkman and Rosen, 1999), among others.

Nevertheless, the focus of our study is on teams with an assigned team leader. According to Zaccaro et al. (2001), even most of the self-managing teams have supervisors who are held accountable by 'higher-ups for team outcomes, and who are responsible for ... providing the team with resources and establishing the normative basis for team functioning' (p.453). Therefore, they very often work as coordinators of the tasks, acting as a very important connection to external teams or management, and as guides for setting the team's vision (Morgeson, 2005; Zaccaro et al., 2001).

Nowadays, the dynamic environment and constant change within organizations makes team decision-making and problem-solving more complex (West, 1996). Teams are faced

with the need to continuously reflect and monitor the environment in order to choose what actions to take (Hoegl and Parboteeah, 2006). West (1996) defines this process of team reflexivity as 'the extent to which a team reflects upon and modifies its objectives, strategies and processes in relation to task-functional environment' (West, 1996: 559). Studies support the notion that team reflexivity plays a key role in team effectiveness and it is positively related with team performance (Hoegl and Parboteeah, 2006; Schippers et al., 2008). Reflexivity has been argued to be instrumental in clarifying differences in task representations between team members. Thus, it may help groups to reach a more shared understanding of task strategies and goals (Pieterse et al., 2011).

Several factors can enhance team reflexivity, with leadership being a key variable. In fact, a team leader might help team members initiate regular and appropriate self-evaluation, and thus help them become more reflexive (Gersick and Hackman, 1990). To respond effectively to the external team environment, teams and their leaders must take strategic decisions. A more 'strategic leader' must execute priorities in a structured way and simultaneously be open to change. This suggests that leaders expand the idea of strategy to include collective learning within the team (Beatty and Byington, 2010). Learning orientation produces favourable task strategies to attain an understanding of the task (Pieterse et al., 2011). In addition, leaders may activate a shared mental model (cf. Kozlowski et al., 1996; van Ginkel and van Knippenberg, in press) and align task strategies, for example, by giving clear directions for the best strategy. Thus, the team will benefit from discussion and focused attention on how strategically it operates (Beatty and Byington, 2010). Similarly, organization leaders must attend to the culture, systems and processes of the organization to ensure that they support strategy as a learning process.

There have been some empirical studies that analyse the relationship between team leadership, reflexivity and performance. Hirst, Mann, Bain, Pirola-Merlo and Richter (2004) found that facilitative leader behaviours were positively related to team reflexivity, which in turn affected clients' evaluations of team performance. Also, Schippers et al. (2008) found that transformational leadership was positively related to team reflexivity and performance, and this relation was mediated by a shared vision within the team. According to the authors, when leaders stimulate shared norms, aspirations and ideals, and show team members how to analyse problems from new perspectives, team members develop a shared vision about the task which in turn enhances team reflexivity.

In this paper, we investigate the role of leadership in teamwork effectiveness by considering the process of reflexivity inherent to teams. Another approach to leadership will contribute towards overcoming some of the limitations in the general theories of leadership and empirical research carried out in this field so far.

Context

The type of context in which teams operate has been neglected in the literature (Kozlowski and Bell, 2003). In fact, teams are embedded in a broader system that influences team processes and outcomes. Beyond theoretical influences that recognize the importance of these contextual influences, 'we know relatively little about the effects of the organizational context on team functioning' (Kozlowski and Bell, 2003: 362). Specifically, research on leadership has been applied to many contexts, but there is little concern about the differences inherent to these contexts. According to Kozlowski et al. (1996), leadership theories need

to be grounded by the characteristics of the contexts. Additionally, Liden and Antonakis (2009) analyse the role of context in the leadership literature and conclude that empirical studies on leadership tend to ignore it, which can be seen as a weakness of the field. There are studies that would indicate that leadership is affected by the team (e.g. Cogliser and Schriesheim, 2000; Henderson et al., 2009; Morgeson and DeRue, 2006), but most of these studies are more grounded at the interpersonal level and less at team level. Moreover, these studies do not consider either the specific tasks that teams have to perform, nor the way the characteristics of the team context can be responsible for its effectiveness, or the role leadership plays in the variability between teams.

The specific context of this study is the Portuguese child abuse and neglect MDT. In the Portuguese System of Children and Youngsters at Risk Protection, Commissions for the Protection of Children and Youngsters at Risk (CPCY), are 'official, not judicial, institutions with functional autonomy that aim to promote the rights of children and the young and to prevent or put an end to situations that may affect their security, health, education and whole development' (Portuguese Protection Law of Children and Youngsters in Danger, article 12).

The CPCY teams are very similar to MDTs in other countries. In terms of the CPCY's legitimacy of intervention, they make decisions regarding the application of measures to protect children and youngsters who are at risk. The composition of these teams is inter-institutional and multidisciplinary, as CPCY members are representatives of several agencies with diverse competencies and an interest in the problems of children and youngsters at risk. However, most members do not work full-time in these MDTs.

The study of team functioning and dynamics of CPCY is crucial to improving effectiveness, as they work on cases where their decisions may drastically affect the children, parents, agencies, family shelters and the life of the whole community. However, empirical studies of these specific teams are practically non-existent. An exception is the study of Torres (2008), who assessed and described CPCY functioning and the action that leaders take, but it was not a review or theoretical reflection on the dynamics inherent in these processes.

With regard to leadership, the theoretical models and empirical studies on the impact of leadership on teamwork effectiveness have generally been applied to for-profit organizations. Although private and public organizations are similar in that the environment is relevant to their activity and they both require leadership skills and competences, leaders of not-for-profit organizations experience specific situations. Both sectors require strong leadership skills, but public and non-profit organizations are often required to operate with fewer resources whilst maintaining an acceptable level of productivity (Ahearn et al., 2004). According to Stid and Bradach (2009), for most non-profit leaders, 'success depends upon providing visionary leadership and making a compelling case for a cause, which in turn drives fundraising and helps them attract and motivate staff and volunteers' (p.63). In the case of the CPCY, the law defines the leadership skills, but the focus is mainly on formal skills. However, despite the important need to precisely determine the essential leadership skills for the good management of CPCY teams, studies on the leaders of these particular MDT teams in Portugal context are not available.

Even regarding other countries, empirical studies on child abuse MDT team leadership or leaders focus on transformational leadership (Smith, 2011), political skills (Ahearn et al., 2004), or leadership training programmes (Zimmerman, et al., 2003). There are also some research studies about the leaders of MDTs in the context of health services (Siden et al.,

2009) and education (Malone and Gallagher, 2010). However, these studies do not focus on team leadership processes in the promotion of team effectiveness.

The resources needed for these teams to perform effectively are also a very important consideration when studying the effectiveness and leadership of CPCY teams. In these teams, besides the efforts of the investment in children welfare services, the resources available for them remain scarce, considering the needs that they face (National Commission of Protection for Children and Youth at Risk, 2011; Ells, 2000). MDTs have to find the resources in the community (not only material resources, but also institutions to call upon) and often have to work with fewer resources due to the limited amount of funds available to them. In addition, there are other MDTs that also have responsibilities in situations where there are abused and neglected children. So the CPCY team members need to know which institutions they can call upon to help them find solutions and resolve the cases. This institutional network is extremely important to the overall performance of the CPCY. In fact, it is recognized that when the multidisciplinary work is effective, cases are resolved with greater success than when there are problems in the community services networks.

Leaders play an important role in promoting and developing community-based networks, and encouraging good interagency practice or interprofessional collaboration at all levels within their own agency (Edwards et al., 2009; Murphy, 2004). It is important that the leader accepts that the child protection work is a shared process, and positive working attitudes towards other agencies should be encouraged among MDT members. Thus, this kind of leadership is more than just an individual style and dyadic relations between a leader and one team member, and particularly, a process regarding an internal share for decisions inside the team. As each team member represents an agency, the leaders in this context should be dedicated to and work for a common purpose and common goals (Cheminais, 2009), should create a positive atmosphere for interagency communication, and facilitate joint planning for multi-agency developments and sharing of information, discussion and planning around the cases in general (Murphy, 2004). By encouraging the participation of all team members, and consequently all agencies, to provide resources, the leader can better guarantee that children and youngsters are provided with the best services and ensure that the team performs effectively.

The current study

Most theoretical models and empirical research on the influence of leadership on team processes and performance assume a synchronic perspective. In the majority of the theoretical models, as we discussed earlier, leadership is seen as a predictor (input variable) or moderator in this relationship. But are these models suitable for studying ongoing teams? In this study we aim to expand the linear models that have so far been used to explain and predict team outcomes.

Based on the working experience with these teams and literature review (Bross et al., 1988; Ells, 2000), we suggest that the success of an MDT is highly dependent on main factors like the ability of the team as a unit to reflect and critically analyse the resources available for a specific case of child abuse or neglect, and the leader's capacity to obtain and manage the resources needed to assure team effectiveness.

Ilgén et al. (2005) also posit that most I-P-O models do not incorporate a temporal perspective of team performance. We agree that leadership is, in fact, an input variable to team effectiveness. But it is also important to rethink what role leadership in fact plays in

ongoing team performance. We believe that to consider leadership as always being at the heart of team performance is a reductive approach. It is our contention that continuous team reflection on tasks can influence leadership, and then leadership in its turn influences ongoing team performance.

The same idea is also present in the work of Zaccaro et al. (2001). The authors put forward the idea of the reciprocal influence that occurs between leadership and processes. Teams can help the leader to interpret environmental ambiguity and reduce uncertainty. Several theories of leadership and team dynamics neglect this fact, which not only leads to a reduced understanding of collective decision-making and team performance, but also has a limiting effect on the training and development of these team leaders.

Another important issue is that most of the traditional models of team leadership are formulated to suit for-profit organizations. More specifically, there are empirical studies about leaders in teams from different contexts, such as education and health services. Hackman (2010) argues that researchers should take into account the radical differences between the contexts of leadership. It is therefore important to speculate on the structural features of social systems that would help leaders to naturally and appropriately take the particular features of their contexts into account as they carry out their leadership work. In an empirical study, Pinnington (2011) found that leadership development in the private sector is more strongly motivated by instrumental economic concerns than in the public and not-for-profit sectors. Moreover, respondents from the public and not-for-profit sectors are less convinced by the importance of some of the private-sector approaches and its dominant values, such as leaders' confidence and power to create effective leadership. This distinction requires further investigation in future research on theories, practices and contexts for leadership development.

Therefore, our study investigated the role that team leadership plays in cycles of ongoing team performance in a context under-explored in leadership studies. Marks, Mathieu and Zaccaro (2001) considered that team tasks are not fixed. Instead, a team's performance occurs during time cycles or different points in time, which are referred to as episodes (Marks et al., 2001). Each episode corresponds to different phases that a team goes through, and each phase may focus on different team processes. Rather than a fixed relationship between the variables, we believe that the proposed model represents an episode of the ongoing performance of the relationship between team reflexivity, team leadership and team effectiveness.

Based on the reviewed literature we formulate, thus, the following hypotheses:

Hypothesis 1: Team reflexivity is positively related to team performance.

Hypothesis 2: Team leadership mediates team reflexivity and team performance.

Hypothesis 3: Team reflexivity is positively related to team satisfaction.

Hypothesis 4: Team leadership mediates team reflexivity and team satisfaction.

The proposed model is represented in Figure 1

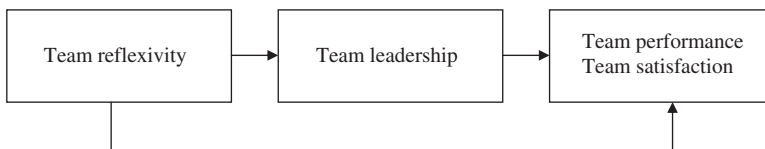


Figure 1. Proposed model.

Method

Sample

In this study, 126 CPCY teams participated (654 individuals), representing 45.2% of all existing CPCY in Portugal. Team size was 9 elements on average ($SD = 2.21$); 76.9% were females and their average age was 39 years old ($SD = 10.29$). With regard to leadership rotation, 62.2% had had a change of leader at least once in the last four years.

Procedure

A survey was sent by email to each CPCY, explaining that the goal of the survey was to collect information from individual team members on several aspects of CPCY functioning. Team members sent their completed surveys back to the research team by email or post.

Measures

All items are shown in the Appendix. They were measured on a seven-point scale with responses ranging from 1 (Totally disagree/Very poor/Very dissatisfied) to 7 (Totally agree/Very good/Very satisfied). A principal component analysis was conducted to test if all scales were measuring the expected constructs. (The results of this analysis are available on request from the corresponding author). Based on the results, we created an index for each measure, with higher scores indicating a higher level of the variables. The Cronbach alphas are shown in Table 1.

Team leadership. Team leadership was measured by seven items adapted from the Team Diagnostic Survey (Wageman, et al., 2005). One example of the items was, 'The CPCY's leader effectively manages the network of local agencies'. Participants answered how much they agree with each statement.

Team reflexivity. To measure team reflexivity, we used five items of the Team Reflexivity Scale (Swift and West, 1998) (e.g. 'My CPCY often reviews the way it works'). Participants indicated how much they agree with each statement.

Team performance. Team performance was measured using eight items adapted from Passos and Caetano (2005). Participants rated their perception of CPCY performance. Two

Table 1. Means (M), standard deviations (SD), F-values (F), aggregate level intercorrelations (R_{wg} , ICC(1), ICC(2)), Cronbach alphas and correlations ($N = 126$ teams).

Variable	M	SD	F	R_{wg}	ICC(1)	ICC(2)	1	2	3	4	5
Team leadership	5.83	.72	3.71**	.81	.23	.73	(.94)				
Team reflexivity	5.07	.70	2.78**	.79	.17	.64	.35**	(.86)			
Team performance management	5.50	.65	2.54**	.82	.15	.61	.54**	.39**	(.88)		
Team boundary spanning	5.50	.61	2.35**	.83	.13	.57	.48**	.17 [†]	.53**	(.75)	
Team satisfaction	5.63	.49	2.33**	.89	.13	.57	.53**	.39**	.60**	.45**	(.89)

* $p \leq .05$; ** $p \leq .001$; [†] $p \leq .1$.

components were extracted from principal component analysis. The first was labelled Team Performance Management (e.g. 'Technical resources management'). The second component was designated Boundary Spanning. This factor involves collaborating with others outside the team, scanning the environment and negotiating resources for the team (Hirst et al., 2004) (e.g. 'Relations with the children and youth agencies').

Team satisfaction. We used six items adapted from Santos, Costa, Passos, Ramalho and Caetano's (2009) satisfaction scale (e.g. 'To what extent are you satisfied with the functioning of your CPCY?'). Participants rated how satisfied they are with each aspect.

Results

Aggregation

The level of analysis in this study is the team. So, for statistical analyses, individual answers were aggregated at team level. In order to assess within-team agreement, we calculated R_{wg} (James et al., 1984, 1993). As can be seen in Table 1, all values are above 0.70, the minimal criteria value for within-group interrater agreement (Cohen et al., 2001). Furthermore, we calculated Intraclass Correlation (ICC) – these values are also reported in Table 1. According to Bliese (2000), ICC(1) must be between 0.05 and 0.20. The ICC(1) values for the variables in this study meet this criterion, except for leadership, which had a value a little above (0.23; see Table 1). We also report ICC(2) values in Table 1. As expected, these values are higher than ICC(1). Based on these results, we decided to aggregate individual answers at team level.

Hypotheses testing

Table 1 presents the variables' means and standard deviations at team level, as well as the variables' correlations matrix. All variables were on average assessed very positively, especially team leadership ($M = 5.83$).

Table 2. Mediating proposed relationships of reflexivity, leadership and effectiveness.

Variables	Team leadership β	Team performance management β	Boundary spanning β	Team satisfaction β
Step 1				
Team reflexivity	.350**			
R^2 adjusted	.116**			
F	17.203**			
Step 2				
Team reflexivity		.385**	.165*	.394**
R^2 adjusted		.284**	.019*	.149**
F		50.195**	3.425*	22.668**
Step 3				
Team reflexivity		.224**	-.004	.240*
Team leadership		.460**	.480**	.440**
R^2 adjusted		.323**	.217*	.315**
F		30.559**	18.777*	29.480**

* $p \leq .05$; ** $p \leq .001$.

To test the mediation hypotheses, hierarchical multiple regressions analysis was performed in line with Baron and Kenny's (1986) procedure. Regarding the first step of mediation, it can be seen in Table 2 that team reflexivity had a positive and significant effect on leadership ($\beta = 0.350$, $p < 0.001$).

With respect to team performance management, reflexivity has a positive and significant effect on this type of performance ($\beta = 0.385$, $p < 0.001$), supporting Hypothesis 1 for team performance management. Table 2 shows that leadership was also positive and significantly related to this performance ($\beta = 0.460$, $p < 0.001$). The beta value of reflexivity on team performance management decreased when leadership was added ($\beta = 0.224$, $p < 0.001$), corroborating Hypothesis 2, the mediation relationship between those two variables. We also performed Sobel tests in order to assess if the beta of the hypothesized mediational model is significant (Goodman, 1960). The test revealed that this beta is significant ($z = 3.37$, $p < 0.000$).

For the boundary spanning, reflexivity had a positive and significant effect on this performance type ($\beta = 0.165$, $p < 0.05$), as shown in Table 2, as proposed by Hypothesis 1. In the second equation, whereas reflexivity had a non-significant effect on boundary spanning ($\beta = -0.004$, $p > 0.05$), the effect of leadership was positive and significant ($\beta = 0.480$, $p < 0.001$). These results suggest a total mediation of leadership between reflexivity and boundary spanning, supporting Hypothesis 2. The results of the Sobel test were significant ($z = 3.33$, $p < 0.000$).

Reflexivity showed a positive and significant effect on satisfaction ($\beta = 0.394$, $p < 0.001$), supporting Hypothesis 3. Table 2 shows that leadership is also positive and significantly related to satisfaction ($\beta = 0.440$, $p < 0.001$). The beta value of reflexivity on satisfaction decreased when leadership was added ($\beta = 0.240$, $p < 0.05$), corroborating Hypothesis 4, the mediation relationship between those two variables. The Sobel test result was significant ($z = 3.30$, $p < 0.000$).

Discussion

In this study, we investigated the role of leadership on teamwork effectiveness. Our model integrates the specific context in which teams act and the fact that these teams already had previous experience working together. We propose that besides being an input variable, leadership can also be a subsequent variable of a team process (namely reflexivity). The hypotheses formulated were that team reflexivity was positively related to team effectiveness (in team performance and satisfaction dimensions), and team leadership mediates this relationship. Results supported the hypotheses with regard to team performance management, boundary spanning and team satisfaction, suggesting the relevance of studying the reciprocal influence of leadership and team processes.

Concerning Hypotheses 1 and 3, results show that reflexivity had significant effects on the two kinds of performance and on team satisfaction. These results suggest that reflexive teams are more likely to question their strategies and processes and respond to environmental challenges, and thus, their actions based on reflection lead to better performance (West, 1996), which is consistent with prior studies (Hirst et al., 2004; Hoegl and Parboteeah, 2006; Schippers et al., 2008). At the same time, it shows that teams that improve the quality of their effectiveness, analysis and interpretation tend to have higher satisfaction with the team (Barry et al., 1999). This, in turn, can generate a higher morale in the team, a better sense of self-fulfilment and greater mutual support in the event of uncertainties and errors.

For Hypothesis 2, results showed that leadership mediated the relationship between reflexivity and performance. We found a partial mediation for team performance management and a total mediation for boundary spanning. A possible explanation for these results is that the CPCY do not have sole responsibility for management and effectiveness, as they are dependent on the government and other agencies. So there are other factors besides leadership that can influence this kind of CPCY performance. With respect to the total mediation, the role of leader as far as the influence of reflexivity on performance is remarkable. Boundary spanning can characterize the more formal role each CPCY leader plays in representing their teams to other agencies.

With regard to Hypothesis 4, leadership partially mediates the relationship between reflexivity and satisfaction. It shows that the role of the leader and the CPCY members' participation in the discussion and decision-making process of cases makes them more satisfied with their own team.

We also suggest that leaders and teams not only reflect to react to the demands of their external environment, but can also actively inform its development, using sense-making. Sense-making involves identifying important environmental events that occur inside and outside the team, interpreting them in the light of the situation in which the team has to operate, and communicating this interpretation to the team (Morgeson, 2005; Zaccaro et al., 2001). In effect, this process not only manages how the team thinks about internal or external events or experiences, such as reflexivity, but also helps the team to understand the significance of specific events and enables the team to cope effectively with their impact.

Consequently, open discussion can help to interpret unfolding events and explore their potential implications, helping the team to gain perspective on its work and challenges, and facilitating the objective use of information needed to adapt to dynamic environments. In an experimental study, Morgeson (2005) found that although a leader's sense-making was negatively related to the team's satisfaction with the leader, it was positively related to team-member judgments of the leader's effectiveness when events became more disruptive.

These are possible explanations, and future studies could analyse these questions in order to reach results that will give us a better understanding of the functions of such leaders, taking into account the context of the MDTs.

Theoretical implications

The results of this study suggest that team leadership research must take a more considered look at the role leadership plays in team processes and teamwork effectiveness. In fact, in most proposed models for team leadership, the leader's role is an input to encourage reflexivity and strengthen team performance (Hirst et al., 2004; Schippers et al., 2008; Zaccaro et al., 2001) or a moderator between inputs and processes and performance (Hackman and Walton, 1986). In general, the authors, having adopted one point of view, are not concerned with discovering the reasons that would explain any discrepancies. In this study, we propose that the characteristics of MDTs and the functions of their leaders can add different leadership roles in I-P-O models. In fact, the concept of leadership has little theoretical or practical utility if the dynamic aspects of teamwork, such as context and time, are not taken into account. Avolio (2007) argues for the need to study the dynamic interplay between leaders and followers while taking into account contextual changes.

Owing to the specificity of the CPCY teams and the more formal role of its leaders, we suggest that team reflection on its processes and teamwork will, in their particular case, give

rise to major concerns with the coordination and leadership of the team. Roe (2008) has highlighted the need to study time to describe human behaviour, as researchers sometimes tend to adopt a static look at some phenomena. For example, several studies have shown that the way in which leaders behave influences the way in which subordinates perform. This can be associated with social learning theory (Bandura, 1977), in which the author has proposed that 'observing others forms an idea of how new behaviors are performed, and on later occasions this coded information serves as a guide for action' (p.22). Proponents of social learning assert that leaders who do not model the desired behaviour undermine the efforts to effect change in their followers (Allen, 2007). However, in most of the studies on leadership, the process of the influence of leaders on subordinates is not formulated in terms of a process influencing another process (e.g. leading team adaptation), but rather as a state influencing other state in a static way (e.g. leadership and team performance) (Roe, 2008).

Another characteristic of the functioning of CPCY, namely, member job rotation, may reflect these results. In fact, according to the legislation, CPCY team members (including the leaders) are appointed by the agencies where they belong for a period of two years, renewable up to six consecutive years. According to Kozlowski et al. (2009), the lifecycle of the team may be strongly affected if the leader is the target of change. However, as teams develop, team institutional knowledge stays not only with the leader, but also with the team members. The success of the leader–team relationship may be achieved through the team's ability to orient the leader to the group, similar to the way in which a leader socializes a new member.

We suggest, therefore, that in future studies with these variables, researchers consider the context in which teams operate, in order to accurately formulate theoretical models about the role the leader plays in the processes and teamwork effectiveness.

Limitations and suggestions for future studies

This study was a correlational one using a survey. To heighten the perception of reflexivity, leadership and performance of CPCY, a methodological triangulation could be used. Furthermore, in addition to using quantitative methods, qualitative methods, such as conducting interviews and case studies, could be employed to achieve a better understanding of the dynamics and leadership behaviour in MDT teams.

The proposed model assumes a direction of causality reflexivity – leadership – performance. According to Shrout and Bolger (2002: 439), 'statistical mediation analyses based on non-experimental data provide suggestive rather than definitive evidence regarding causal processes'. In other words, the reverse causality (e.g. performance enhances reflexivity) must be studied. To study directionality, experimental and longitudinal research would be needed.

The importance of context has already been mentioned. In this study, just one context and type of team was considered. Future studies could compare the role of leadership in different contexts to verify if there are different influences of leadership in I-P-O teamwork effectiveness models.

Analysing teams within their specific context provides a broader view of their effectiveness. In fact, teams operate in a social context and organizational systems structure, which in turn influence its individual members (Hackman, 1992; Kozlowski and Bell, 2003). The CPCY teams, despite their autonomy, are embedded in a complex organizational context with diverse partner agencies. The fact that members are representatives of certain agencies with specific interests can affect their work in the CPCY, and consequently, their team leadership, reflexivity and performance perception. Multilevel approaches will be needed

to study the effects of context on the leadership process, and the functioning of the team and its individual members.

Practical implications

We started this article by giving attention to multidisciplinary teams and their intervention with children and youngsters at risk, as well as the role of their leaders and their effectiveness. It is extremely important to rethink the leader's role in these organizations. CPCY leaders do not always work full-time in CPCY and are representatives of other agencies, as are all other members, and there are no selection criteria for the job.

However, beyond the formal skills already designated and regulated in child protection law, leadership behaviours and skills must be taken into account in leader selection. This process must be planned. It would also be useful if there could be a period of overlap so that the outgoing leader could work alongside the incoming leader to pass on their expertise and knowledge of a particular context. Any future leader must also first have experience as a team member before taking on the role, and those who are already part of the CPCY should elect them. At the same time, leadership training sessions on coordinating these teams are being reduced. So in future, training sessions in this area must be arranged.

Results of this study also suggest that reflexivity is positively associated with team performance, which is interesting for leaders and team members. However, the fact that many teams do not take time for moments of reflection, the emphasis being on action, contributes to those teams not learning from past activities. Focus on training in that area would help teams create such habits and encourage reflexive practices. This reflexivity will reflect positively on the search for best leader behaviours and, thus, a more effective team performance.

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Appendix

Questionnaire

Team leadership

The president of my CPCY...

- (1) Overcomes the uncertainties of the available information.
- (2) Takes initiatives to help the team build and use members' knowledge and skills well.
- (3) Tries to make one learn from mistakes.
- (4) Promotes the individual development of team members.
- (5) Gives feedback to the team taking into account the competencies of each member.
- (6) Manages the content and process of team meetings.
- (7) Effectively manages the network of local agencies.

Team reflexivity

My CPCY often reviews its objectives.

- (1) We regularly discuss if our CPCY is working with effectiveness.

- (2) The methods used by my CPCY to perform are often discussed.
- (3) In this CPCY, we change our goals according to the circumstances.
- (4) We often discuss about how we communicate.

Team performance

Rate the performance of CPCY with respect to the following aspects:

- **Team performance management**

- (1) Fast response to new cases
- (2) Human resources management
- (3) Technical resources management
- (4) Information management

- **Boundary Spanning**

- (1) Relations with CNPCJR (national agency)
- (2) Relations with Family and Children Court
- (3) Relations between extended and restricted CPCY
- (4) Relations with children and young agencies

Team satisfaction

Satisfaction with...

- (1) Your CPCY
- (2) Your CPCY functioning
- (3) The communication between CPCY members
- (4) The results achieved by your CPCY
- (5) The work you perform in this CPCY
- (6) The relationships' climate between your CPCY members.